

Desperate for money to fuel their aspirations, a growing number of young men are either staging their own kidnapping or of members within extended families

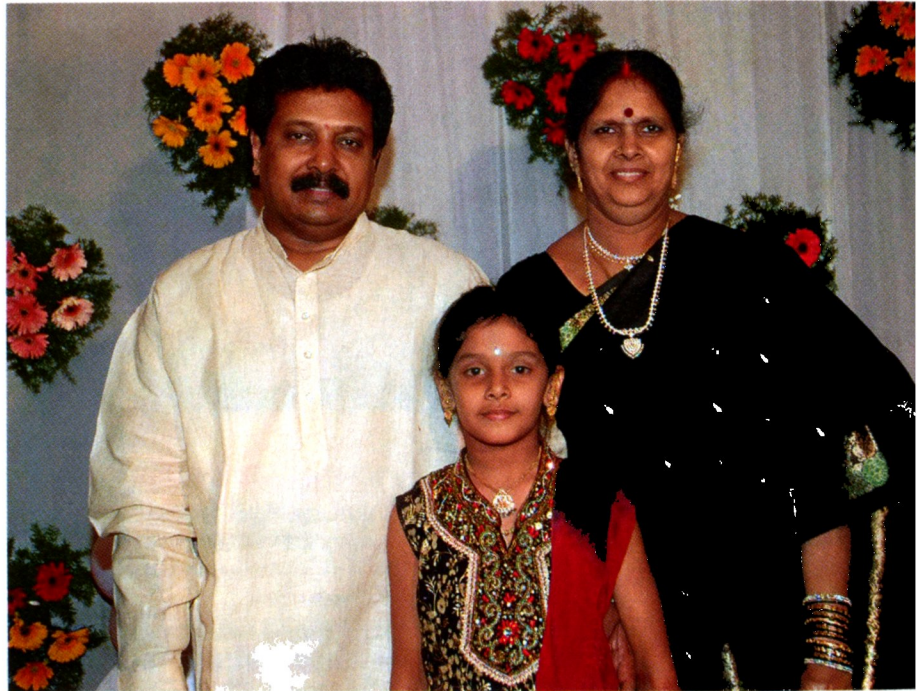
All in the

By Mihir Srivastava

Last month, Vaishnavi, daughter of Vijayawada-based liquor and real estate baron Palagani Prabhakar, was kidnapped for the second time in her short life of 10 years. This time, the ending was tragic: on February 2, her charred body was recovered from a foundry in Autonagar in Guntur—60 hours after she was kidnapped. Unable to deal with the tragedy, her father succumbed to multiple heart attacks the same day. What made it a greater tragedy was that the ghastly act was, according to the police, a conspiracy hatched allegedly by her stepmother Venkateswaramma and her brother Venkat Rao over a family dispute involving sharing of property and business assets. In this high-profile case, the police have made two arrests suspecting that Venkat allegedly paid Rs 50 lakh to his cousin and owner of the foundry, Srinivasa Rao, and his worker Jagdish to execute the kidnapping and murder.

Family involvement in crimes such as kidnapping has shown an alarming rise. Pawan Verma, 22, from Delhi wanted to spend New Year's Eve at the gambling resort of Macau, a demand made by his girlfriend. Short of money for the trip, he staged his own abduction and demanded Rs 8.5 lakh from his father Ram Sahay, a businessman. Verma was caught in the act of picking up the ransom money at a shopping mall.

Verma is just one of the many young men who are resorting to blackmailing their parents and family members by either staging their own kidnapping or of other members within extended families. As the list



VAISHNAVI KIDNAPPING

Vaishnavi, 10

Daughter of Vijayawada-based liquor and real estate baron Palagani Prabhakar, she was kidnapped and killed last month. It is alleged to be a conspiracy hatched by her stepmother and her brother over a family dispute involving sharing of property and business assets.

gets longer by the day, the reasons for in-family kidnappings remain broadly the same: need and greed for money to quench consumerist urges or to settle scores. What is disturbing is that this trend indicates a new breeding ground for criminals in a society driven by rapid economic growth and sudden affluence. The inequitable distribution of the fruits of fast economic growth has made it indigestible for society at large, conclude experts, putting pressure on traditional values and the institution of family itself.

In July 2009, Yash, 2, was allegedly kidnapped by his maternal

grandfather Dharam Singh, who runs a security agency, with the help of his minor son. A resident of Delhi's Amar Colony, Singh demanded Rs 1 crore as ransom. The child was found a week later at an orphanage in Gohana in Sonapat district. Then there was the case of Ajit Sharma, an iron trader and shop-owner in Ghaziabad, who staged the kidnap of his 12-year-old son with the help of two others and tried to put the blame on a business rival. The police got suspicious when the boy was recovered unharmed within two days of the kidnapping from a neighbouring town without the